



Meetings 5–8: Clarifying Essential Learning

PLC Question 1 — What do we want students to learn? One journey, one form, four steps.

The big picture

These four meetings are one journey, not four separate tasks. You start from your course's standards and narrow to a shared, concrete picture of what students must learn and what proficiency looks like — so the common assessment you design next is built on one definition, not five. One form, the Essential Learning Map, travels with your team across all four meetings and holds the whole record.

Meeting	What your team does	Recorded on the Map
Meeting 5 Identify	Use the REAL filters — Readiness, Endurance, Assessed, Leverage — to choose the one essential standard to guarantee this cycle.	Step 1 · Essential standard
Meeting 6 Deconstruct	Break that standard into learning targets — the knowledge and skills behind it — in student-friendly “I can...” language.	Step 2 · Learning targets
Meeting 7 Define proficiency	Agree on what “they’ve learned it” looks like, and build success criteria for the targets.	Step 3 · Success criteria
Meeting 8 Calibrate	Write proficiency anchors, compare them, and refine your success criteria into one shared picture.	Step 4 · Proficiency anchors

How the pieces stack: the standard is the promise → the learning targets are the steps → the success criteria are how you'll know a student arrived. A completed Essential Learning Map is your team's end product for this cycle.

One form, one tool per step

Your team carries a single form — the Essential Learning Map — and completes one step each meeting. Use the Solution Tree tool linked in each step to do the thinking; record the result on the Map.

Meeting	Think with	Record on
5	Using REAL to Identify Essential Standards (Solution Tree)	Essential Learning Map · Step 1
6	Deconstructing an Essential Standard (Solution Tree)	Essential Learning Map · Step 2
7	Gaining Shared Clarity · Developing a Success Checklist (Solution Tree)	Essential Learning Map · Step 3
8	Proficiency Anchors think sheet (EMS)	Essential Learning Map · Step 4

Meeting 8 builds a shared definition of proficiency — but it is not scoring calibration. You can't truly calibrate scores until students have taken the common assessment, so that real calibration comes later, after the first CFA. For now, the team agrees on what proficient looks like and records it on the Map.

Model examples

Not sure what a finished Map looks like? See a completed example for your subject and grade — [Essential Learning Map: modeled examples by subject & grade](#) — to model the end product you're aiming for by Meeting 8.